

Rip Van Winkle

Washington Irving · 1819

First published: The Sketch Book, 1819

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Sketchbook_of_Geoffrey_Crayon_(1819)/Rip_Van_Winkle (revision 15556862), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Rip Van Winkle suggest about change and time?
- What does Rip Van Winkle suggest about the American Revolution?
- What does Rip Van Winkle suggest about escape from responsibility?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Rip Van Winkle	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*change and time* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Rip Van Winkle

Focus: waking into a changed nation

Content note (mild drinking, a scolding wife played for comedy): Sensitive content: Mild drinking; a scolding wife played for comedy. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes mild drinking; a scolding wife played for comedy.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Good-natured, idle Rip Van Winkle wanders into the Catskill Mountains to escape his scolding wife, meets strange men in old Dutch dress playing ninepins, drinks their liquor, and falls asleep. He wakes twenty years later, bearded and stiff. In the village, King George's portrait has become George Washington, his wife is dead, and the Revolution has happened. He settles into old age telling his story.

Background: Published in 1819 in The Sketch Book under the persona 'Geoffrey Crayon' and the fictional historian Diedrich Knickerbocker; Irving adapted a German folktale.

Significance: One of the first American short stories to become a national myth.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: If you fell asleep for twenty years, what would surprise you most when you woke? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes mild drinking; a scolding wife played for comedy.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are dismembered, conciliating, vexations, revisit, amphitheatre. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, and lording it over the surrounding country." In this sentence it means: cut a body into pieces. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Rip Van Winkle would have known. Published in 1819 in The Sketch Book under the persona 'Geoffrey Crayon' and the fictional historian Diedrich Knickerbocker; Irving adapted a German folktale. Why does this story matter? One of the first American short stories to become a national myth. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "On waking, he found himself on the green knoll whence he had first seen the old man of the glen." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to waking into a changed nation? I circle "occurrences", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *On waking, he found himself on the green knoll whence he had first seen the old man of the glen. He rubbed his eyes--it was a bright sunny morning. The birds were hopping and twittering among the bushes, and the eagle was wheeling aloft, and breasting the pure mountain breeze. "Surely," thought Rip, "I have not slept here all night." He recalled the occurrences before he fell asleep. The strange man with the keg of liquor--the mountain ravine--the wild retreat among the rocks--the woe-begone party at ninepins--the flagon--"Oh! that flagon! that wicked flagon!" thought Rip--"what excuse shall I make to Dame Van Winkle?"*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Irony, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Rip Van Winkle develops the idea of waking into a changed nation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to change and time? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about waking into a changed nation, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes waking into a changed nation. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dismembered (verb)	cut a body into pieces	*They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, and lording it over the surrounding country.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conciliating (adjective)	friendly and trying to win good will	*Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt to be obsequious and conciliating abroad, who are under the discipline of shrews at home.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vexations (noun)	annoyances; worries	*In old times, say the Indian traditions, there was a kind of Manitou or Spirit, who kept about the wildest recesses of the Catskill mountains, and took a mischievous pleasure in wreaking all kind of evils and vexations upon the red men.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
revisit (verb)	visit again	*He determined to revisit the scene of the last evening's gambol, and if he met with any of the party, to demand his dog and gun.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
amphitheatre (noun)	a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)	*Passing through the ravine, they came to a hollow, like a small amphitheatre, surrounded by perpendicular precipices, over the brinks of which impending trees shot their branches, so that you*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		only caught glimpses of the azure sky, and the bright evening cloud.	
counterpart (noun)	something very like another; a copy	*Rip looked, and beheld a precise counterpart of himself as he went up the mountain; apparently as lazy, and certainly as ragged.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
obsequious (adjective)	attempting to win favor from influential people by flattery	*Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt to be obsequious and conciliating abroad, who are under the discipline of shrews at home.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
narrated (verb)	provide commentary for a film, for example	*Knickerbocker by a little German superstition about the Emperor Frederick der Rothbart and the Kypphauser mountain; the subjoined note, however, which had appended to the tale, shows that it is an absolute fact, narrated with his usual fidelity.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
precipices (noun)	a very steep cliff	*Passing through the ravine, they came to a hollow, like a small amphitheatre, surrounded by perpendicular precipices, over the brinks of which impending trees shot their branches, so that you only caught glimpses of the azure sky, and the bright evening cloud.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
occurrences (noun)	an event that happens	*The birds were hopping and twittering among the bushes, and the eagle was wheeling aloft, and breasting the pure mountain breeze. "Surely," thought Rip, "I have not slept here all night." He recalled the occurrences before he fell asleep.*	“occurrences”: From Latin occurrere "to run to meet," from ob- "toward" + currere "to run." (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/occurrence)

Discussion questions

1. If you fell asleep for twenty years, what would surprise you most when you woke?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with change and time?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23,

24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why does Rip go into the mountains? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: To escape his wife's scolding
2. What game are the strange men playing? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Ninepins
3. How long does Rip sleep? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Twenty years
4. What has replaced King George on the inn's sign? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: George Washington
5. Who is the 'Rip Van Winkle' leaning against a tree? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Rip's grown son
6. Retell the three most important events of “Rip Van Winkle” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Good-natured, idle Rip Van Winkle wanders into the Catskill Mountains to escape his scolding wife, meets strange men in old Dutch dress playing ninepins, drinks their liquor, and falls asleep. He wakes twenty years later, bearded and stiff. In the village, King George's portrait has become George Washington, his wife is dead, and the Revolution has happened. He settles into old age telling his…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Rip Van Winkle”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Rip Van Winkle” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, and lording it over the surrounding country.” What does “dismembered” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dismembered: cut a body into pieces.
10. Reread: “Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt to be obsequious and conciliating abroad, who are under the discipline of…” What does “conciliating” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: conciliating: friendly and trying to win good will.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Rip Van Winkle” suggest about waking into a changed nation? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: One of the first American short stories to become a national myth.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about waking into a changed nation? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
4. In the passage that begins “On waking, he found himself on the green knoll whence he had first seen the old man of the glen.”, why might Irving have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Rip Van Winkle”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Good-natured, idle Rip Van Winkle wanders into the Catskill Mountains to escape his scolding wife, meets strange men in old Dutch dress playing ninepins, drinks their liquor, and falls asleep. He wakes twenty years later, bearded and stiff. In the village, King George's portrait has become George…
6. As the opening story, what does “Rip Van Winkle” set up that the rest of Rip Van Winkle will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “If you fell asleep for twenty years, what would surprise you most when you woke?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with change and time? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in 1819 in The Sketch Book under the persona 'Geoffrey Crayon' and the fictional historian Diedrich Knickerbocker; Irving adapted a German folktale. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “One of the first American short stories to become a national myth.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Rip Van Winkle” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about waking into a changed nation? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Rip Van Winkle”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

5. Connect this story to the American Revolution: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Irving need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "Rip Van Winkle" treats waking into a changed nation with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Rip Van Winkle see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve change and time? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about waking into a changed nation? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Washington Irving about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. Why does Rip go into the mountains?
   A. To find gold
   B. To hunt a bear
   C. To escape his wife's scolding
   D. To fight the British
2. What game are the strange men playing?
   A. Cards
   B. Dice
   C. Chess
   D. Ninepins
3. How long does Rip sleep?
   A. One night
   B. Seven years
   C. Twenty years
   D. A hundred years

4. What has replaced King George on the inn's sign?
   A. Rip himself
   B. A ship
   C. A bear
   D. George Washington
5. Who is the 'Rip Van Winkle' leaning against a tree?
   A. Rip's grown son
   B. A ghost
   C. A stranger
   D. Rip's grandson
6. In the line “They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, and lording it over the surrounding country.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?
   A. friendly and trying to win good will
   B. annoyances; worries
   C. cut a body into pieces
   D. visit again
7. In the line “Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt to be obsequious and conciliating abroad, who are under the discipline of shrews at home.”, what does “conciliating” most nearly mean?
   A. visit again
   B. cut a body into pieces
   C. annoyances; worries
   D. friendly and trying to win good will

Answer key: 1. C (To escape his wife's scolding); 2. D (Ninepins); 3. C (Twenty years); 4. D (George Washington); 5. A (Rip's grown son); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (friendly and trying to win good will)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Rip Van Winkle,” how does Irving show waking into a changed nation? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In Rip Van Winkle, how does Irving develop the idea of waking into a changed nation? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Rip Van Winkle develops the idea of waking into a changed nation. Make a precise claim, support it with

at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Rip Van Winkle (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of waking into a changed nation. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Rip Van Winkle suggests about waking into a changed nation. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Washington Irving uses setting in Rip Van Winkle to complicate the reader's understanding of waking into a changed nation. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Rip Van Winkle within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of waking into a changed nation responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Rip Van Winkle alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of waking into a changed nation follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Rip Van Winkle and its treatment of waking into a changed nation. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Rip Van Winkle as evidence for a larger claim about waking into a changed nation in Rip Van Winkle. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Rip Van Winkle as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of waking into a changed nation. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Rip Van Winkle.

SAT-style questions

1. *In old times, say the Indian traditions, there was a kind of Manitou or Spirit, who kept about the wildest recesses of the Catskill mountains, and took a mischievous pleasure in wreaking all kind of evils and vexations upon the red men.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "vexations" most nearly mean?

   A. a very steep cliff
   B. an event that happens
   C. provide commentary for a film, for example
   D. annoyances; worries

2. *On waking, he found himself on the green knoll whence he had first seen the old man of the glen. He rubbed his eyes--it was a bright sunny morning. The birds were hopping and twittering among the bushes, and the eagle was wheeling aloft, and breasting the pure mountain breeze. "Surely," thought Rip, "I have not slept here all night." He recalled the occurrences before he fell asleep. The strange man with the keg of liquor--the mountain ravine--the wild retreat among the rocks--the woe-begone party at ninepins--the flagon--"Oh! that flagon! that wicked flagon!" thought Rip--"what excuse shall I make to Dame Van Winkle?"*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Rip Van Winkle"?

   A. Racial pride destroying love
   B. Waking into a changed nation
   C. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle
   D. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

SAT key: 1. D (annoyances; worries); 2. B (Waking into a changed nation)

Whole-book test

Rip Van Winkle: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why does Rip go into the mountains?
   A. To find gold
   B. To hunt a bear
   C. To escape his wife's scolding
   D. To fight the British
2. What game are the strange men playing?
   A. Cards
   B. Dice
   C. Chess
   D. Ninepins
3. How long does Rip sleep?
   A. One night
   B. Seven years
   C. Twenty years
   D. A hundred years
4. What has replaced King George on the inn's sign?
   A. Rip himself
   B. A ship
   C. A bear
   D. George Washington
5. Who is the 'Rip Van Winkle' leaning against a tree?
   A. Rip's grown son
   B. A ghost
   C. A stranger
   D. Rip's grandson
6. In the line “They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, and lording it over the surrounding country.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?
   A. friendly and trying to win good will
   B. annoyances; worries
   C. cut a body into pieces
   D. visit again

7. In the line “Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt to be obsequious and conciliating abroad, who are under the discipline of shrews at home.”, what does “conciliating” most nearly mean?
   A. visit again
   B. cut a body into pieces
   C. annoyances; worries
   D. friendly and trying to win good will
8. As used in the story (“They are a dismembered branch of the great Appalachian family, and are seen away to the west of the river, swelling up to a noble height, an”), what does “dismembered” mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
   C. provide commentary for a film, for example
   D. friendly and trying to win good will
9. As used in the story (“Indeed, to the latter circumstance might be owing that meekness of spirit which gained him such universal popularity; for those men are apt ”), what does “conciliating” mean?
   A. something very like another; a copy
   B. friendly and trying to win good will
   C. a very steep cliff
   D. annoyances; worries
10. As used in the story (“In old times, say the Indian traditions, there was a kind of Manitou or Spirit, who kept about the wildest recesses of the Catskill mountain”), what does “vexations” mean?
    A. attempting to win favor from influential people by flattery
    B. an event that happens
    C. annoyances; worries
    D. visit again
11. As used in the story (“He determined to revisit the scene of the last evening's gambol, and if he met with any of the party, to demand his dog and gun.”), what does “revisit” mean?
    A. provide commentary for a film, for example
    B. cut a body into pieces
    C. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
    D. visit again
12. As used in the story (“Passing through the ravine, they came to a hollow, like a small amphitheatre, surrounded by perpendicular precipices, over the brinks of whi”), what does “amphitheatre” mean?
    A. a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater)
    B. a very steep cliff
    C. friendly and trying to win good will
    D. something very like another; a copy

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how change and time develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how the American Revolution develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how escape from responsibility develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (change and time, the American Revolution, escape from responsibility) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (To escape his wife's scolding); 2. D (Ninepins); 3. C (Twenty years); 4. D (George Washington); 5. A (Rip's grown son); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (friendly and trying to win good will); 8. A (cut a body into pieces); 9. B (friendly and trying to win good will); 10. C (annoyances; worries); 11. D (visit again); 12. A (a sloping gallery with seats for spectators (as in an operating room or theater))

Essay assignments

Essay: Change and time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rip Van Winkle teaches about change and time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops change and time in Rip Van Winkle. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops change and time across Rip Van Winkle. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rip Van Winkle (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of change and time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of change and time in Rip Van Winkle. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in Rip Van Winkle (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of change and time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rip Van Winkle's treatment of change and time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on change and time in Rip Van Winkle that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on change and time in Rip Van Winkle. Name your critical method,

apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about change and time in Rip Van Winkle, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on change and time in Rip Van Winkle, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The American Revolution

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rip Van Winkle teaches about the American Revolution. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops the American Revolution across Rip Van Winkle. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rip Van Winkle (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the American Revolution. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in Rip Van Winkle (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the American Revolution, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rip Van Winkle's treatment of the American Revolution in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the American Revolution in Rip Van Winkle, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Escape from responsibility

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rip Van Winkle teaches about escape from responsibility. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops escape from responsibility across Rip Van Winkle. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rip Van Winkle (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of escape from responsibility. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in Rip Van Winkle (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of escape from responsibility, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rip Van Winkle's treatment of escape from responsibility in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on escape from responsibility in Rip Van Winkle, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.